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536118 (36)

MBA (1st Semester)

Examination, Nov.-Dec., 2010

Branch : Management

COMPREHENSIVE CASE ANALYSIS

Time Allowed : Three Hours

Maximum Marks : 80

Minimum Marks : 32

Note : (i) Solve any two cases out of three.

(ii) Answer must be chronological order.

(iii) All case carry equal marks.

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CASE – 1

"The Vice President, The Product Manager and The Misunderstanding"

Ameya Sharma, one of the field sales managers of Major Tools work, was promoted to his first head quaters assignment as an assistant product manager for a group of products with which he was relatively unfamiliar. Shortly, after he undertook this new assignment, one of the company's vice president, Vijay Dewan, called a meeting of product manager,and other staff to plan marketing strategies. Amey's immediate superior, the product manager, was unable to attend, so

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the director of marketing. Ashok Sapru, invited Amey to the meeting to help orient him to his new job.

Because of the large number of people attending, Ashok was rather brief in introducing Amey to Vijay, who, as vice president, was presiding over the meeting. After the meeting began, Vijay–a crusty veter an with a reputation of bluntness began asking a series of questions that most of the product managers were able to answer in detail. Suddenly he turned to Ameya and began to question him quite closely about his group of products. Somewhat confused, Ameya confessed, that he did not know the answers.

It was immediate apparent to Ashok that Vijay had forgotten or had failed to understand that Amey was new to this job and was attending the meeting more for his own orientation, than to contribute to it. He was about to offer a discreet explaination when Vijay, visibly annoyed with what he took to be Amey's lack of preparation, announced, "Gentlemen, you have just seen an example of sloppy staff work, and there is no excuse for it !" http://www.csvtuonline.com

Ashok had to make a quick decision. He could interrupt Vijay and point out that he had judged Amey unfairly, but that course of action might embaress both

his superior & subordinates. Alternatively, he could wait until after the meeting and offer an explanation in private. In as much as Vijay quickly become engrossed in other conversation, Ashok decided to follow the second approach. Glancing at Amey, Ashok noted that his expression was one of mixed anger and dismay. After catching Amey's eye, Ashok winked at him as a discreet reassurance that he understood and that the damage could be repaired.

After an hour, Vijay evidently dissatisfied with what he termed the "inadequate planning" of the marketing department in general, abruptly declared the

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meeting over. As he did so, he turned to Ashok and asked him to remain behind for a moment. To Ashok surprise, Vijay himself immediately raised the question of Amey. In fact, it turned out of have been his main reason for asking Ashok to remain behind. "Look" he said, I want you to tell me frankly, do you think I was too rough with that kid ?" Relieved, Ashok said, "Yes, you were. I was going to speak to you about it."

For a moment, Ashok took the measure of his superior. Then he replied evenly, "I dont know him very well yet. But, I think you hurt him."

"Damn, that's unforgivable", said Vijay he then telephoned his secretary to call Amey and ask him to

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report to his office immediately. A few moments later, Amey returned, looking perplexed and uneasy. As he entered, Vijay came out from behind his desk and met him in the middle of the office. Standing face to face with Amey, who was 20 years and four organization levels his junior, he said, "Look, I've done something stupid and I want to apologize. I had no right to treat you like this. I should have remembered that you were new to your job. I'm sorry."

Amey was somewhat frustrated but muttered his thanks for the apology.

"As long as you are here, young man." Vijay continued," I want to make a few things, clear to you in

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the presence of your boss's boss. Your job is to make sure that people like myself don't make stupid decisions. Obviously we think you are qualified for your job or we would not have brought you in here. But it takes time to learn any job. Three months from now I will expect you to know the answer to any questions about your products. Until then," he said thrusting out his hand for the younger man to shake, "You have any complete confidence and thank you for letting me correct a really dumb mistake."

Questions :

(i) What do you think was the effect of Vijay's outburst on the others managers at the meeting ?

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(ii) Was it necessary for Vijay to apologize to Amey ? Why ?

(iii) How does Vijay define Amey's responsibility as an assistant product manager ? How does he define his own role as top manager ?

(iv) What would it be like to have Vijay working for you ? To work for Vijay ?

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CASE – 2

Motivating Partners at Starbucks"

Starbucks, with more than 3,300 location worldwide serves millions of coffee lovers each week.

Having a history of excellent growth and profitibility, starbucks continues to expand. It opens "virtually a store a day." In addition to sales of whole bean coffees, fresh brewed espresso beverages, pastries & infections, and coffee related accessories and equipment in company operated retail stores. starbuck sells whole coffee beans through other outlets including supermarkets & online. It also manufactures and sells a line of premium ice-creams & bottled frappuccino coffee drink.

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Famed for its coffee products, company also enjoys a glowing reputation as a progressive employer

known for its employee policies & motivational programmes, starbucks has been included in fortune magazines' List of "The Hundred Best companies to work for" in 1998, 1999 & 2000.

The basis of starbucks reputation as a great place to work is contained in the six guiding principles that formed the foundations of the companies mission statement. One of these guiding principles is to "provide a great work environment and treat each other with respect and dignity." Starbuck tries to "create a work environment that is lively, exciting, and full of enthusiasm."

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One ovest symbol of the guiding principle in the name to all starbucks' employees. Everyone is called a partner. More important than the name, however, is a company culture devoted to developing and motivating the partners. " Starbucks has created a culture dedicated to challenging employees. To be their Best", starbuck is dedicated to investing in supporting and engaging its partners in the continual reinvention of the company.

The challenge to "be their best" begins with training. All new coffee store employees (referred) to as Baristas) receive 25 hour of classroom training under

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the guidance of partners who have been especially trained. The training includes coffee knowledge & customer service skills. Management trainees participate in upto 12 weeks of classes. They also receive coaching on leadership skills, diversity awareness, advance customer service, succession planning and career development.

Starbucks motivational program for its partners consist of " a special blend of employee benefit". and a work life/ personal life program that focuses on the physical, emotional, mental and creative aspects of each individual.

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The company offers a comprehensive benefits package to all partners including part time employees who work for minimum of 20 hrs per week. The benefit package includes full medical and dental insurances coverage, disability and life insurance, vacation days, a retirement saving plan with matching company contribution, discounted stock purchase plan, and stock options, as part of starbuck BEANSTOCK programme. Starbuck established the BEANSTOCK program in 1991 as a way of investing in the employer partner in creating ownership through out the company.

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The work/life programme includes onsite fitness services, flexible work schedules, referrals and educational support for child care & elder care issues, and a program that links employee who have shared interests and hobbies. Starbuck continually seeks to develop programmes that address the life stages & personal needs of its partners. Infact, the company conducts periodic surveys of its partners to assess their needs and it responds accordingly with appropriate work/life solutions. "We will ask our partners constantly whats important to them and consider these things as we plan into the year 2003 and beyond", says starbuck manager.

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Open communication and innovative thinking both of which positively influence the partner's motivation are encouraged through various partner relations mechanism. These mechanisms include mission review, open forums, and the norm regards recognition program. Mission Review, encourages partner to tell the company how they are feeling and ask any question." Open forums are held on a regular basis to review performance, recognize achievements, and consider the future. The warm regards program recognizes "outstanding achievement that embodies the guiding principles, mission, and goods of starbuck".

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These programs benefit both the partners and the company. One of the benefits for starbuck is a reduction in operating costs. The company has relatively low health care costs, reduced absenteeism and one of the lowest turnover rates in the restaurant industry. The lower turnover rate also reduces training costs. Another benefit for starbucks is the quality of customer service that grows out of the partners committment to the company.

"We're profitable because of the value system of our company observes Howard Schultz, starbucks chairman and chief global strategist. "American

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company has failed to realize that there's tremendous value in inspiring people to shave a common purpose of self-esteem, self respect & appreciation" starbuck is "about people–a humanistic approach to doing business that produces bottom-line results."

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Questions :

(i) Give starbuck 'benefits package and work/life program what insights have you gained about its approach to employee motivation ? Explain your answer.

(ii) What needs does starbucks appeal to through its benefits package, and work/life program ?

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(iii) What is important to you in terms of your personal work motivation ? How do the things that motivate you fit with starbuck's approach to motivating partners ?

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CASE – 3

"The Dabbawalas of Mumbai"

The Dabbawalas of Mumbai carries hot lunches from of employees (customers) to their places of employment. The Aluminimum containers or "Tiffins" serve the dual purpose of keeping the food warm & preventing it from splashing out during the tiffin carrier's

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rushed & justling journey. A typical tiffin carrier carries about 40 of these dabbas on a long, unwiedly tray on his head as he moves speedly through busy streets & cramped trays. The tray and tiffins have a combined weight of more than 60 kg for distances over 4 km, the carriers often use bicycles; when carrying more than 40 tiffins, the carriers use hand carts.

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Each dabbawala is employed by one of the city's 800 contractors (mukaddams). The contractors and Tiffin carriers both belong to the Mumbai tiffin box carrier's association. It was registered as a trust in 1967, but was an informal guild of some 50 years before this.

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There are two primary reasons why the tiffin carrier operations started and suceeded in Mumbai. First, the Indian value systems places great emphasis on have cooked meals, served hot. The problem for roughly 8 out of 10 white collar workers in Mumbai is that they do not have time to go for lunch to home. The tiffin carrier brings the security of an inexpensive, clean, tasty, and often still warm, home cooked meal, Restaurant meals cost 5 to 15 times more than home cooked food and there is also the chance of falling ill. As many public eat cateries lack hygienic kitchens. Second, Mumbai is the only city in India where the train

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traffic flaws in the North south direction & the pedestrian traffic flaws in the east-west direction. Thus, tiffins, are physically carried for relativily short distances from home to train stations by on set of tiffin carried by train for longer distances between stations, and finally carried by other tiffin carriers from the train stations to the designated work places. Therefore, Mumbai alone can sustain a tiffin carrier network of this size and complexity because of it quick, efficient and far-reaching sub-urban train service.

Most of the Mumbai's tiffin carriers and contractors come from the Pune region, roughly 150

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miles away from Mumbai. A tiffin carrier does not have to pay the contractor to be hired. There is absolutely no paper work involved. Trust and loyalty are the main underpinnings of recruitment. Typically, no formal training is provided to the tiffin carrier to be hired. However, for the first two days, the tiffin carriers follows, his contractor of another dabbawala who shows the new recruit his route, the homes / apartments he would visit to pick up of tiffins in the morning and to which he would return tiffins in the afternoon, and to which he would return tiffins and explain the coding/identification

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system. A tiffin will visit upto 40 hours each day and he must learn the location of all of them during his two-day orientation. All the training is done orally.

A dabbawala is usually paid a fix–straight salary of Rs 1000/- a month by his contractor. There are no other benefits provided to the tiffin carrier, except that he gets a week's vacation in march apart from public holidays. By contrast, contractors make between Rs. 6000/-and Rs 8000/- a week. There is no policy regarding sick leave or absenteeism. A worker is expected to be at work. If a worker gets sick, other tiffin

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carriers in his group or his contractor may cover for him. The bond among tiffin carriers is as strong as the old school tie. They wont entertain any talk of dishonesty in the ranks. Trust is the essence of the business and a tiffin carrier typically sticks to his contractor.

The contractors basically run the business through two committees: The Mandal Committee & The Trust Committee.

The members of the Mandal Committee are 11 contractors who are elected for 5 years. The

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committee collectively governs the trust but its primary responsibilities seem to be dealing with brokering conflicts among contractors and addressing potential contractors The trust committee, also camprises 11 contractors, each elected for 5 year period, is responsible for the operation of the courtesy in (Dharamsalas) back home in Pune. In addition, two contractors serve as staff to the trust. The job of these two contractors includes: (i) resolving disputes and problems arising in day to day operations that cannot be resolved by contractors and their groups.

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(ii) Enroling new customers into business and

(iii) Arranging and calling meeting of the trust. The contractors, in turn, are responsible to the Mumbai Tiffin box carriers association. The Mandal organizers monthly meetings. The tiffin carriers can also attend the monthly meeting if they so desire. The internal problems / disputes between the contractors are sorted out at these business meetings by the Mandal committee. Additionally, the tiffin carriers and contractors meets socially once a month. These meeting are organized by the trust.

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The turst has some 5,800 members, making it a large scale operations. Some 5000 workers, called carriers; some 800 supervisors as managers, called contractors and the 11 member mandal committee. a flat organisation such as this often implies a wide span of control.

There is a relatively high degree of specialization. There are a limited number of different jobs and each involves relatively narrow range of tasks. The job corresponds to the three phases of work : (i) A pick up of the filled tiffins from the homes of the employees and

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to deliver to the employees at their work place. (ii) Train transportation of tiffins between residential and commercial places and (iii) delivery of empty tiffins back to their homes.

A consequence of high specialization in increased task interdependence, hence for the need of coordination mechanism, such as standardization, to accomplish results.

In the morning each tiffin is collected which has a different symbol as each tiffin in bound for different destination. The alpha-numeric character and the colour

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of 'dot' tells the carrier of the destination of each tiffin. Tiffins are collected by a set of workers from the residences of the employees which is passed on to the another set of workers who take these tiffins on bicycle or hand-carts to the trains. Another set of workers collect the tiffins at the destination train station & deliver it to the employees. In the afternoon, the reverse process is followed to deliver the empty tiffin back to home.

The tiffin carrier system is a conjoint structure that falls squarely under arborescent systems. It

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involves the transfer of same 2,00,000 lunch boxes collected everyday from an equal number of sources, and deliver to some 80,000 destinations the same day within a time window of 3 hours. Dabbawala's registers an out standing performance on both counts – cost and reliability of delivery.

Questions :

(i) What team & inter-team processes are reflected in the operation of the dabbawala system ?

(ii) How has the dabbawala system responded to the changing context of the life of office goers in Mumbai ?

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(iii) What cultural factors have on contributed to the spectacular success of the system ?

(iv) What values & which aspects of positive perspective are reflected in the successful working of the dabbawala system ?

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